

Docker

From Chaos to Containers

A beginner's guide to containerization

Shipping Containers

- Before Containers (1950s)
 - Different shapes, sizes, materials
 - Hard to stack, organize, transport
 - Lots of wasted space
 - Manual loading/unloading

- After Containers (1960s+)
 - **Standardized** size and shape
 - **Stackable** and organized
 - **Portable** across ships, trucks, trains
 - **Efficient** loading with cranes

Why Do We Need Docker?

- The Software Development Problem:
 - "It works on my machine!"
 - "But, I don't know why it does not work on users' machine!"

Traditional Problems

- Different operating systems
- Different software versions
- Missing dependencies
- Environment configuration issues
- Deployment headaches

Docker Solves These Problems

- Just like shipping containers Docker standardizes software deployment:
 - **Consistent** environments
 - **Portable** applications
 - **Isolated** processes
 - **Scalable** infrastructure
 - **Reproducible** builds

- The Software Development Problem Solved:
 - "It works on my machine!"
 - "So, I ship the environment that my machine is built together with the application."
- We already observed this solution pattern before
 - Python venv

What is Docker?

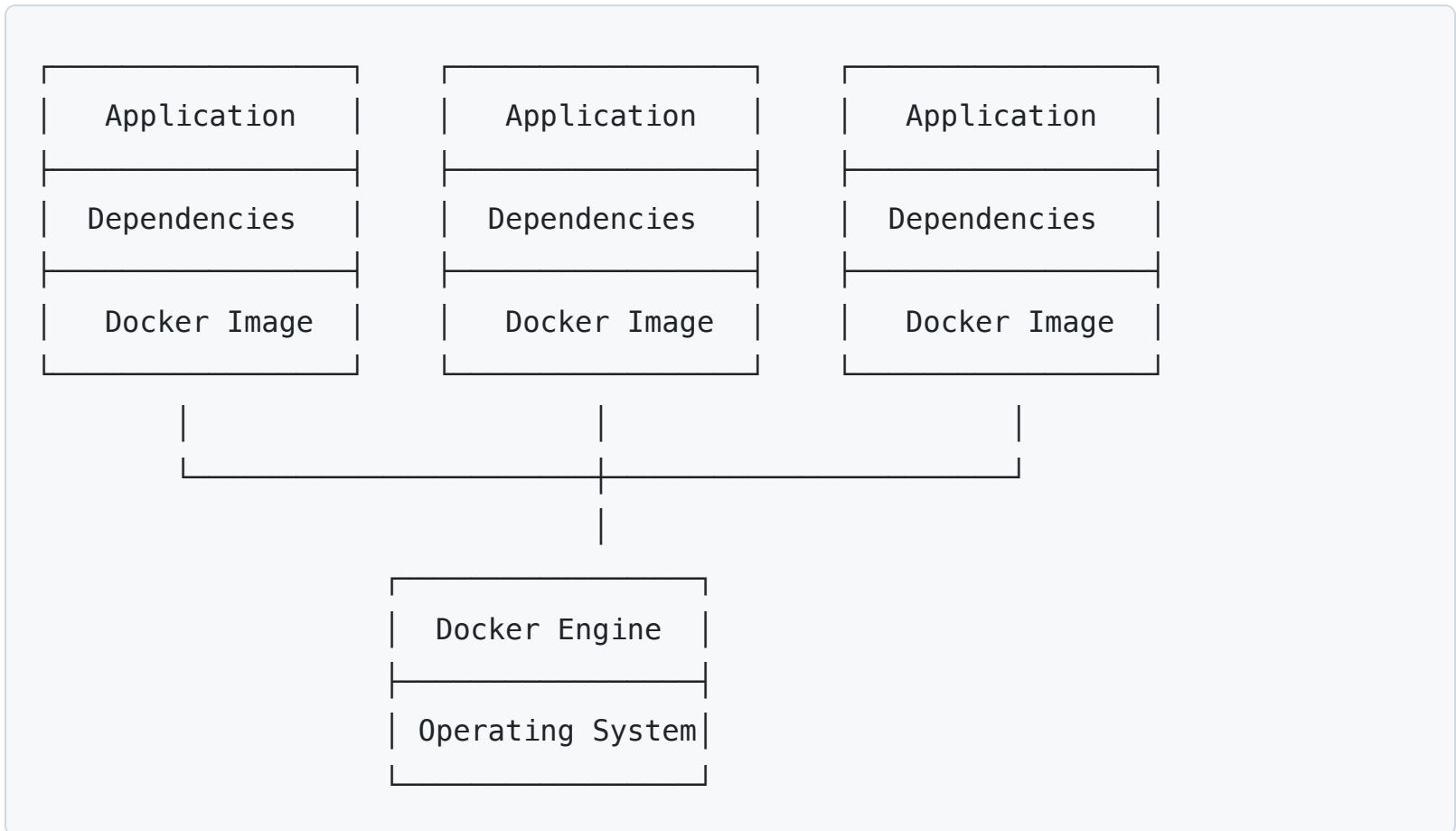
- Docker is a platform that uses **containerization** to
 - package applications
 - and their dependencies together.

Key Concepts

- **Container:** Like a shipping container for your app
- **Image:** Blueprint/template for containers
- **Dockerfile:** Recipe to build images
- **Registry:** Warehouse for storing images (Docker Hub)

Docker Architecture

- Applications are executed in isolation.



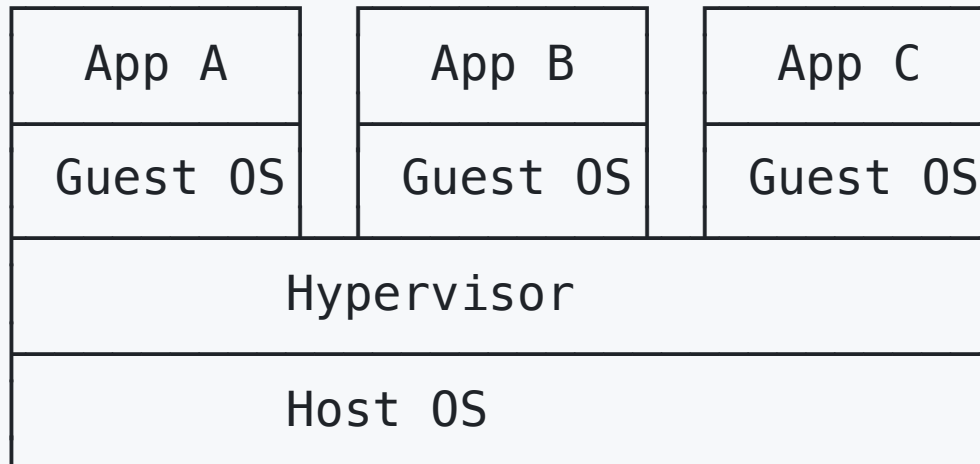
Warning: Docker is not

Notice: **Docker packages your server environment, not your user application**

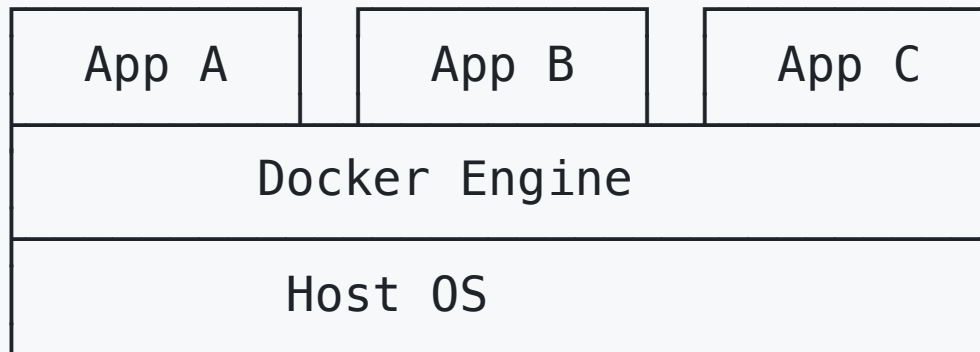
- **Servers:** Need consistent, isolated environments → Use Docker
- **End Users:** Need native, easy-to-install apps → Use traditional installers

Containers vs Virtual Machines

- Docker is not a virtual machine



- Docker is a container (isolator).
 - Practically no performance issue.
 - Easy to build and deploy.



Basic Commands

- Essential Docker Commands

```
# Download an image
docker pull nginx
# Run a container
docker run -d -p 8080:80 nginx
# List running containers
docker ps
# Stop a container
docker stop <container_id>
```

Docker Desktop

- Download and use [Docker Desktop](#).
 - It supports all the Docker CLI.
 - We can manage Docker images and containers.

Dockerfile: The Recipe

- What is a Dockerfile?
 - A text file with instructions to build a Docker image
- Java Analogy
 - Source code: Dockerfile
 - Class file: Docker Image
 - Object in memory: Docker Container

Simple Dockerfile Example

- Building a Node.js Application
 - We write down the same process we do when we use Node.js in the Dockerfile.
- The last line has the command that we use for starting the application.
 - `CMD ...`

```
# Start with a base image (like choosing your kitchen)
FROM node:18-alpine

# Set working directory (prepare your workspace)
WORKDIR /app

# Copy dependency list (shopping list)
COPY package*.json ./

# Install dependencies (buy ingredients)
RUN npm install

# Copy application code (bring your recipe)
COPY . .

# Expose port (set the table)
EXPOSE 3000

# Start the application (cook and serve)
CMD ["node", "app.js"]
```

Building and Running

```
# 1. Create the Docker image (t means tag)  
docker build -t my-node-app .
```

```
# 2. Run the container (p means port)  
docker run -p 3000:3000 my-node-app
```

```
# 3. Access your app  
# Open browser: http://localhost:3000
```

What happened?

- Docker read your recipe (Dockerfile)
 - Java compiler (javac) reads your source file (.java)
- Docker compiles the Dockerfile into a Docker Image.
 - javac compiles the code into a class file.

- Docker Runs the Image in Memory; Now the Image becomes a Container.
 - java virtual machine loads the class in memory and execute it; Now the class becomes an object.

Docker Compose: The Orchestra

- What is Docker Compose?
 - Tool for defining and running **multi-container** applications

Real-world analogy

- **Single Container = Solo musician**
- **Docker Compose = Full orchestra**
 - Perfect for:
 - Web app + Database
 - Frontend + Backend + Database
 - Microservices architecture

Docker Compose Example

- Web Application with Database

```
version: '3.8'

services:
  # Web application (Frontend)
  web:
    build: .
    ports:
      - "3000:3000"
    depends_on:
      - database
    environment:
      - DATABASE_URL=postgresql://user:password@database:5432/myapp
```



```
# Database (Backend storage)
database:
  image: postgres:15
  environment:
    - POSTGRES_USER=user
    - POSTGRES_PASSWORD=password
    - POSTGRES_DB=myapp
  volumes:
    - postgres_data:/var/lib/postgresql/data

volumes:
  postgres_data:
```

- In this example, we use two containers:
 - Web application
 - Database backend storage that the web application relies upon.

```
# Web application (Frontend)
web:
  build: . # searches for Dockerfile
...
database:
  image: postgres:15
```

- Based on this compose file:
 - Docker builds the web application Docker image from the Dockerfile in this (.) directory.
 - Docker builds the database server by pulling image from a repository.

Docker mapping

- Docker maps local port/directory to the port/directory in the Docker image.

```
ports:  
  - "3000:3000"  
volumes:  
  - postgres_data:/var/lib/postgresql/data
```

Docker Compose Commands

- Managing Your Orchestra

```
# Start all services (entire orchestra plays)
docker-compose up
# Start in background
docker-compose up -d
# Stop all services (silence the orchestra)
docker-compose down
# Rebuild services
docker-compose build
```